

Case Study 2: Loss of Two-case System in Old French

Classical Latin, which was in active use as a written language from the 1st century BCE to the 3rd and 4th centuries CE, possessed a rich six-case morphological system with an additional marginal case (Klein et al., 2017). Much later in the 13th century CE, Old French and Old Occitan were the last remaining Romance languages with a morphological case system. Modern Romance languages have no case markers at all and instead rely on word order to convey similar meaning. In this paper, Old French will be examined as a case study for how a rich case marking system like in Latin could eventually collapse. In this case, possible reasons for the collapse of Old French's two-case system include internal weakness, sound change, and syntactic shift.

According to Klein et al. (2017), in Old French, the two remaining cases were known as *casus rectus* (nominative) and *casus obliquus* (oblique). These cases were derived from Latin nominative and accusative, respectively. *Casus rectus*, then, was used primarily for marking the subject and *casus obliquus* primarily for marking direct objects (Einhorn, 1974). The following examples illustrate basic usage of *casus rectus*:

Old French

- (1) Charles est vieu-z
Charles.NOM.M.SG be.3SG.PRES old-NOM.M.SG
'Charles is old.'

- (2) Aymes!
Aymes.NOM.M.SG
'Aymes!'

- (3) Charles, li roi-s
Charles.NOM.M.SG the.NOM.M.SG king-NOM.M.SG
'Charles, the king.'

(Einhorn, 1974)

Example 1 shows the nominative case marking the subject (Charles). Since this is an equative construction, the adjective (*vieu-z*) also matches the nominative case. Example 2 shows an additional usage of the nominal case in Old French, identifying the person or thing being addressed. Example 3 shows that appositives or descriptors, including articles, also agree with nouns in the nominative case. Further examples illustrate basic usage of *casus obliquus*:

Old French

- (4) La mere-Ø voi-t Aymon
the.NOM.F.SG mother-NOM.F.SG see-3SG.PRES Aymes.ACC.M.SG

‘The mother sees Aymes.’

(5) La mere-Ø Aymon
the.NOM.F.SG mother-NOM.F.SG Aymes.ACC.M.SG

‘The mother of Aymes.’

(6) Por Aymon, le baron-Ø
for Aymes.ACC.M.SG the.ACC.M.SG baron.ACC.M.SG

‘For Aymes, the baron.’

(Einhorn, 1974)

Example 4 shows the oblique case marking the direct object, or whom the mother is seeing. Again, this is the most common usage. Example 5 shows how the oblique case can also be used for expressing possession. Similar to the nominative case in Example 3, Example 6 demonstrates case agreement with appositives and descriptors, including articles. The following example shows how the two-case system allows for flexible word order:

Old French

(7) Or fier-ent chevalier-Ø païen-s
now strike-3PL.PRES knight-NOM.M.PL infidel-ACC.M.PL

‘Now the knights strike the infidels.’

(Einhorn, 1974)

Since the nominative and oblique cases have distinct endings, they can more freely move around. The verb may also help disambiguate roles if the subject and object are a different person or number. In practice, the verb normally comes before the subject as above.

Table 1. *Articles and nouns*

1. Articles				
	Definite		Indefinite	
	Masc.	Fem.	Masc.	Fem.
Nom.Sing.	<i>li</i>	<i>la</i>	<i>uns</i>	<i>une</i>
Obl.Sing.	<i>le</i>	<i>la</i>	<i>un</i>	<i>une</i>
Nom.Plur.	<i>li</i>	<i>les</i>	<i>un</i>	<i>unes</i>
Obl.Plur.	<i>les</i>	<i>les</i>	<i>uns</i>	<i>unes</i>
2. Masculine nouns				
	Class I	Class II	Class III	
NS	<i>(li) murs</i>	<i>(li) pere*</i>	<i>(li) ber</i>	
OS	<i>(le) mur</i>	<i>(le) pere</i>	<i>(le) baron</i>	
NP	<i>(li) mur</i>	<i>(li) pere</i>	<i>(li) baron</i>	
OP	<i>(les) murs</i>	<i>(les) peres</i>	<i>(les) barons</i>	
3. Feminine nouns				
	Class I	Class II	Class III	
NS	<i>(la) rose</i>	<i>(la) loi(s)</i>	<i>(la) none</i>	
OS	<i>(la) rose</i>	<i>(la) loi</i>	<i>(la) nonain</i>	
NP	<i>(les) roses</i>	<i>(les) lois</i>	<i>(les) nonains</i>	
OP	<i>(les) roses</i>	<i>(les) lois</i>	<i>(les) nonains</i>	

* Class II (M) nouns at times add *-s* in the NS ≠ Class I (M).

Table 1: Articles and nouns (Einhorn, 1974)

The above table shows how different nouns decline based on their gender, number, and declension class. There are only two morphemes which convey all of this information, *-Ø* and *-s*. Class 3 also utilizes *-(i)ere* and *-eor* for masculine nouns and *-e* and *-ain* for feminine. Articles also decline based on gender, number, and case as shown.

The first possible reason for the dissolution of this case system and the one posited in the *Handbook of Comparative and Historical Indo-European Linguistics* is that the irregularity and asymmetry of the system, or its “internal weakness” was unmaintainable (Klein et al., 2017). Observe how the *-s* morpheme fulfills different roles depending on the gender and class of the noun (see Table 1).

For masculine nouns, for instance, *-s* marks the oblique case in plural nouns. For some masculine nouns, like those in class 1, *-s* also marks nominative singular. So, the *-s* morpheme could mean either oblique or nominative depending on the number. The absence of *-s* could also mean either oblique or nominative. This system already demonstrates some needless complexity, but there is more.

For feminine nouns, the meaning of the *-s* morpheme changes. It also means both nominative and oblique, but chiefly in the plural. Some class 2 feminine nouns exhibit an *-s* morpheme in the nominative singular form, but this too is irregular. In contrast with the masculine paradigm, the feminine paradigm is highly asymmetrical. Only about half of the case and number forms match across gender.

Put simply, the theory is that the overall complexity of the two-case system and the irregularity of the *-s* morpheme creates undue cognitive load. It became easier for speakers to simply drop the case system and deal with the ambiguity that creates than to keep the system and its utility or innovate a new one (Klein et al., 2017).

While it may appear that the loss of a case system resulted in a large reduction in overall complexity, the complexity may have simply shifted from one system to another while also cutting back on some contradictions. What was once accomplished by morphological case endings in Old French is now accomplished by modern analytic French syntax with its own rules and patterns. The collapse of the case system is closely tied to the evolution of word order.

Before the Romance languages emerged, Latin underwent a shift from SOV word order to VSO or SVO word order (Klein et al., 2017). Old French mostly used the VSO word order as described above, but finally evolved to use a rigid SVO word order around the 17th century CE, a few centuries after the case system collapsed. In other words, the case system collapse occurred right in the middle of a syntactic shift which lasted several centuries. The

rigid SVO word order now effectively fulfills the role that the case system once accomplished. SVO languages also generally favor prepositions which could assist in this task (Fortson, 2010).

On the other hand, the main factor keeping the entire case system functioning was a single *-s* morpheme. It could have been possible that a simple sound change led to the downfall of the whole system. In colloquial speech and later in writing, final consonants in Old French were gradually omitted before a following consonant (Einhorn, 1974). Naturally then, it is quite possible that the final /s/ underwent apocope as well under these conditions. Later, the elision of final /s/ could have more easily expanded to all environments.

In summary, a combination of factors could have led to the collapse of the Old French two-case system. In its final form, the case system was highly irregular and asymmetrical. The cognitive burden was simply not worth the utility it provided. At the same time, syntactic changes were occurring which supported the dropping of cases such as a more rigid SVO word order. The natural elision of final consonants also applied some pressure to the collapse. Altogether, the loss of the Old French case system became an inevitability to reduce unnecessary complexity. This case study also gives us some potential clues for how the other Romance languages developed in the same way. Namely, while the phonology of those languages may differ, they share the same syntactic shift initiated by Latin.